# Muhammad Usman Naeem

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## Education

**Tufts University** — Medford, MA, USA
Ph.D., Economics & Public Policy — Expected 2027
*Fields:* Environmental; Development; Behavioural; Public

**Lahore University of Management Sciences** — Lahore, Pakistan
M.S., Economics — 2016

**National University of Singapore** — Singapore
B.A., Economics — 2009

## Research Positions

**Harvard University, Department of Economics** — Cambridge, MA, USA
Visiting Fellow — Jan–Jun 2026

**International Growth Centre (LSE–Oxford)** — Pakistan
Country Economist — 2015–2021

## References

| **Steve Cicala** | **Michael Greenstone** | **Gabriel Kreindler** | **Kyle Emerick** |
|---|---|---|---|
| steve.cicala@tufts.edu | mgreenst@uchicago.edu | gkreindler@g.harvard.edu | kyle.emerick@tufts.edu |

## Job Market Paper

### "The Idle Margin: Why Everyday Conservation Goes Undone"


*Abstract.* Vehicle idling—leaving the engine running while stopped—poses a recurring conservation puzzle: for sufficiently long stops, switching off saves drivers money on fuel while reducing emissions, so private and social incentives point in the same direction. Why, then, do drivers persist in idling? In partnership with a leading telematics firm in Pakistan, I collect 10-second GPS data on ignition status, speed, and location from 6,621 private vehicles. The average vehicle idles for 27 minutes per observed day. At baseline, drivers hold widespread misperceptions about whether warming up an engine extends engine life and how long a stop must last before shutting off saves fuel or reduces environmental harm. I use a randomised additive design varying private information, social information, payments, and an in-car reminder technology. Private information reduces daily idling from stops longer than 30 seconds by 1.8 minutes, or 9% of the control mean, and the effect persists after treatment ends. Estimated benefits are 3.7 times programme costs over the eight-week intervention, with about half accruing directly to drivers through fuel savings. Adding either social information or payments produces no detectable additional reduction. By contrast, activating the reminder device *increases* idling by 1.0 minute, with the increase concentrated in long spells—a pattern consistent with procrastination. The results show that everyday conservation failures can persist even when private and social incentives align—and that interventions meant to correct them can backfire.

## Working Papers

**"Subsidies and Debt under Nonlinear Electricity Pricing"**
with Robin Burgess, Tim Dobermann, Michael Greenstone, and Faraz Hayat

**"Preaching Against Power Theft"**
with Robin Burgess, Tim Dobermann, Michael Greenstone, and Faraz Hayat

**"Hardening the Grid: Technology versus Enforcement"**
with Robin Burgess, Tim Dobermann, Michael Greenstone, and Faraz Hayat

## Selected Work in Progress

**"Technology Subsidies and Crop Residue Burning"**
with B. Kelsey Jack, Ben Moscona, and Michael Greenstone

**"Small Farms, Coordination, and Air Pollution"**
with Steve Cicala and Kyle Emerick

**"Industrial Pollution and Emissions Disclosure"**
with Michael Greenstone

## Research Grants

Total funding as PI/Co-PI: over $1.1 million.

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| £57,463 (IGC); $13,972 (Weiss) | The Idle Margin: Why Everyday Conservation Goes Undone |
| £277,762 (IGC) | Subsidies and Debt under Nonlinear Electricity Pricing |
| $167,904 (Weiss; K-CAI); £64,097 (IGC) | Preaching Against Power Theft |
| £124,677 (IGC); $24,874 (Weiss) | Hardening the Grid: Technology versus Enforcement |
| $109,938 (ATAI; DERF); £24,919 (IGC) | Technology Subsidies and Crop Residue Burning |
| £31,172 (IGC) | Small Farms, Coordination, and Air Pollution |
| £66,272 (IGC) | Industrial Pollution and Emissions Disclosure |

## Presentations (* forthcoming)

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| 2027 | Econometric Society CSW Asia Meeting* |
| 2026 | NEUDC*; SMU–Jinan / WB–GWU Urbanization & Development Conference*; Harvard, Cities & Development Workshop*; LUMS; Tufts, NFEPP Workshop; Harvard, Development Advising Group |
| 2025 | Stanford, Behavioral Public Economics Boot Camp; Tufts, NFEPP Workshop |
| 2024 | Berkeley, Environmental & Energy Economics Summer School; Tufts, NFEPP Workshop |
| 2023 | MIT, Behavioral Economics; Tufts, NFEPP Workshop |

## Teaching

**Tufts University** — Medford, MA, USA

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|---|---|
| Lecturer, Environmental Economics (undergraduate) | 2026–2027 |
| Teaching Assistant, Advanced Empirical Methods for Doctoral Students | 2026–2027 |
| Tutor, Intermediate Macroeconomic Theory (undergraduate) | 2025–2026 |
| Course Assistant, Behavioral Economics (graduate) | 2023–2026 |